



Picking Exercises

For each major upper body muscle group we are going to pick 2 exercises that train the muscle group in different ways (eg. bias different regions), whereas for lower body we will pick 2~3 exercises that train the whole lower body and keep a more minimalist approach.

Upper body

Chest and Shoulders

For chest shoulders we want to synergize:

Chest press + lateral raise on one day, and shoulder press + pec fly on the other day, thus minimizing overlap

We also want 1 upper pec chest exercise and 1 “flat” chest exercise

*Anything from S-tier is going to be great, if you don't have access to it use the “Not as good” category

Upper pec presses (S-tier):

- Reverse grip smith machine press
- Neutral grip machine press
- Tucked elbow smith incline press
- Hammer strength incline press (don't lock out, since it is hardest at the top and locking out makes it triceps biased)

Not as good:

- Tucked elbow dumbbell incline press
- Tucked elbow dumbbell flat press

Upper pec flyes (S-tier):

- Seated low to high cable fly (the best, especially if you can cuff around your wrist)

Not as good:

- Incline dumbbell fly with more tucked elbows

*basically anything other than seated low to high cable fly is quite mid

Flat pec presses (S-tier):

*For this, try to have minimal arching, even using a flat back if you want

- Flat machine press (pronated grip)

- Flat smith machine bench press

Not as good:

- Flat dumbbell presses (with more flared elbows)

Flat pec flyes (S-tier):

- Pec deck machine (goated exercise)
- Pec deck machine with elbow pad
- Seated cable fly (not as good as pec deck machine)

Not as good:

- Dumbbell fly

My choice: Reverse grip smith bench press and Pec deck machine

Shoulder press (S-tier):

- Smith behind the neck press (great for side delts)
- Smith shoulder press (use wider grip, and slight incline so the bar doesn't smash your head)
- Machine shoulder press (pronated grip, best choice IMO)

Not as good:

- Seated barbell behind the neck press
- Seated dumbbell press (elbow more flared)

Lateral raise (S-tier):

- Cable lateral raise
- Machine lateral raise (depends largely on your machine)

Not as good:

- Any dumbbell lateral raise variation
- *Upright row

My choice: Machine shoulder press and cable lateral raise

(Paired with pec deck and reverse grip smith bench respectively)

Back (Lats, traps, rear delts)

For back we want to synergize:

Iliac lat exercise + upper back row on one day, and thoracic lat exercise + upper back row/kelso shrug on the other day

Iliac lats (S-tier):

- Wide grip weighted pull up
- Wide grip pulldown (any: cables, machines)
- Keenan flap
- Wide grip assisted pull up (if you're weak)

Thoracic lats (S-tier):

- Neutral grip chest supported machine row
- Chest supported dumbbell row (tucked elbow)
- Helms dumbbell row (tucked elbow)
- One arm dumbbell row
- Cable/Machine pullover (arms only up to 90 degrees)

Not as good:

- Close grip cable row

Upper back rows (S-tier):

- Pronated grip chest supported machine row
- Tbar row
- Chest supported dumbbell row (flared elbows)

Not as good:

- Wide grip cable rows

Kelso shrugs (S-tier):

- Tbar kelso shrug
- Chest supported machine row kelso shrug
- Bench supported smith kelso shrug

Not as good

- Chest supported dumbbell kelso shrug

My choice: Wide grip weighted pull ups + pronated grip chest supported machine row, one arm dumbbell row + tbar kelso shrug

Biceps

For biceps do 1 lengthened bias (preacher) curl, and 1 mid-range curl. Use a "hammer variation" of mid-range curl if you are not doing dedicated forearm training

Lengthened biased curls (S-tier):

- Ez bar preacher curl
- Dumbbell preacher curl (off a bench)
- "Recline curls" (look it up on tiktok for demo)

Mid range curls (S-tier):

- Cable curls
- Seated dumbbell curls

Not as good:

- Standing barbell curls

Hammer variations:

- Hammer cable rope curls
- Seated dumbbell hammer curls

My choice: Ez bar preacher curl + seated dumbbell curls

Triceps

For triceps pick 1 pushdown with 1 tricep press, or 1 pushdown and the dumbbell pullover

Pushdowns (S-tier):

- Vbar pushdown
- Single arm cuff pushdown
- Poliquin push down (incline bench)

Not as good:

- Rope pushdown, or other attachments

Tricep presses (S-tier):

- Chest press machine JM press
- Smith machine JM press
- Machine Tricep dips

Not as good:

- Weighted tricep dips

My choice: Single arm cuff pushdown + dumbbell pullovers

Forearms

For forearms pick 1 wrist flexion curl and 1 brachioradialis curl

Wrist curl (S-tier):

- Single arm dumbbell wrist curls off a bench (spot with other arm)
- Sam sulek cable wrist curls
- One arm cable wrist curls

Not as good:

- Standing dumbbell wrist curls
- Behind the back barbell wrist curls
- Basic barbell wrist curls

Brachioradialis curl:

- Cuffed single arm top half reverse curl (most “optimal”)
- Dumbbell reverse curl (hold lower on the dumbbell so the weight naturally pronates)
- Ez bar reverse curl
- Cable reverse curl

My choice: Single arm dumbbell wrist curl off a bench + dumbbell reverse curl

Abs

If you checked off the narrow waist wide hips in the “Structural Assessment” document, then include 1 ab exercise and 1 obliques exercise, if not just pick 2 ab exercises.

Abdominal exercises (S-tier)

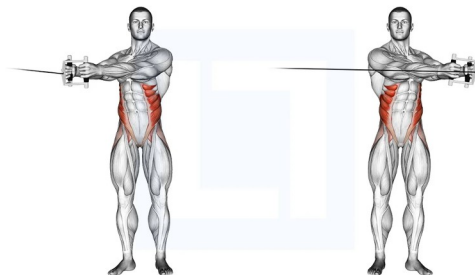
- Standing cable crunch (use a squat pad on the cable machine for your ass)
- Decline sit ups (hold the weight behind your head)

Not as good:

- Kneeling cable crunch
- Weighted leg/knee raises (hold dumbbell with your feet)

Oblique exercises:

- Side twists from a pec deck machine



- Side twists from a cable machine

Lower body

For lower body, we want to pick 2~3 exercises that can train the whole lower body (to the extent we want and place it lower priority in our training. Make 2 combinations of these 2~3 exercises:

Compound exercises:

- Machine Squat/Leg press: effectively trains quads, adductors, glutes
- Hip thrusts: effectively trains glutes, and still trains the quads and adductors (albeit not as well as a squat)
- SLDL: effectively trains the glutes, adductors, and hamstrings
- Back extensions: effectively trains the glutes and hamstrings (free weights for more hamstrings, banded for more glutes)

Isolation exercises

- leg curl: hamstrings
- leg extensions: quads
- adductor machine: adductors
- single leg calf press on selectorized leg press machine: calves

Example combinations (you can add on calves if you want):

SLDL + leg extensions = quads, glutes, adductors, hamstrings

Smith squat + leg curl = quads, glutes, adductors, hamstrings

back extension + leg extension + adductor machine = quads, glutes, adductors, hamstrings

leg curl + hip thrusts = glutes, hamstrings, quads (submaximal), adductors (maintain)

My choice (glute and hamstrings biased): leg curl + hip thrusts, back extensions + hack squats

Maximalist leg day example:

Leg curl

leg press

SLDL

leg extension

adductor machine

calf press